

How did you get interested in developing computerized trading systems?

When I was about 9 or 10 years old, I became interested in odds and probability. I would obsessively roll a pair of dice to see seven win, and six and eight duke it out. It just fascinated me to see the results come out over time—to see the randomness, but also the certainty with which seven would always beat six and eight.

When I was 12, I read about computers. It was an article about the new Commodore, a \$300 computer, which in today's terms would be several thousand dollars. I convinced my parents to buy the computer for me, but because it was so expensive, they agreed only on the condition that I return it in time for the 30-day money back guarantee. It was that or no computer at all for me. This Commodore was the type of computer where you saved your files on a cassette tape, which I thought was really neat technology. The thing I wanted to program was rolling dice, so I could roll dice faster. It felt a little weird having a computer decide what was random and not seeing the dice, but it was fun writing the program. To get more time on the computer before I had to return it, I even skipped school for a couple of days by pretending to be sick, using the old thermometer-near-the-lightbulb trick.

How did you teach yourself programming?

I think there was some sort of manual. Also, it was such a simple program except for the random number generation, which was a function already programmed on the computer. Even though I begged my parents to keep the computer, they sent it back. But I am really glad I got to do 30 days of programming back then. I think it was a really good thing for my evolving brain to experience. I did very little programming again until college.

Were any other childhood experiences influential in your becoming a trading system developer?

Absolutely! A year earlier, I had gotten really interested in baseball statistics after my grandfather, who lives in Pennsylvania, took me to see the Philadelphia Phillies, my favorite baseball team. I calculated and recorded full-page statistics on the Phillies from the box scores in the